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HST 243: Soviet History Through Film

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How were youth and generational change depicted in Soviet films from the 1960s?

The years of the 1960s in the Soviet Union encompassed the end of Nikita Khrushchev's rule and the beginning of Leonid Brezhnev's regime. The following era was characterized by relative cultural liberation and social stability, which allowed the Soviet youth to explore their identities and express themselves. Consequently, the greater freedom led to the emergence of conflicts between the young and the old inside Soviet societies, resulting in a fundamental generational break. This phenomenon was well-documented in media of the period, with cinematography being one of the major reflections of it. Soviet films of the 1960s marked a profound generational shift by offering the image of a new wave of youth who prioritized personal aspirations over collective ideals, grew up in the absence of father figures, and exhibited strong detachment from cultural and ideological values of the past.

To be specific, Soviet films of the period framed personal ambitions as the central driving force behind young people's decisions, presenting a more lively generation that valued individual fulfillment over collective duty. In other words, monumental changes in the lives of the youth were dictated by their individualistic aspirations, dreams, and goals, which did not necessarily align with the collective ideals or sense of greater socialist community. According to the discussion of Lewis Siegelbaum's chapter by Dina Fainberg and Artemy Kalinovsky, "...young people in the kolkhozes took their fates in their own hands and embarked on life-changing journeys to study, work, and settle in the cities."¹ One of the notable cinematic realizations of this

¹ Fainberg, Dina & Kalinovsky, Artemy. "Stagnation and Its Discontents: The Creation of a Political and Historical Paradigm" In *Reconsidering Stagnation in the Brezhnev Era: Ideology and Exchange*, edited by Dina Fainberg and Artemy Kalinovsky. (Lexington Books: 2016), 16.

phenomenon is *Walking the Streets of Moscow*, which featured the story of a young Siberian writer, Volodya Yermakov. Motivated by the recognition from publishers of Moscow, Volodya independently traveled to the capital and subsequently was entrusted with an important task from an established literary expert (Figure 1).



Figure 1. Voronov talking to Yermakov from *Walking the Streets of Moscow*

Although the director implemented secondary plotlines for Yermakov's development as a character, establishing contact with Moscow authors remained the primary objective of his visit. The prioritization of this goal did not simply indicate the ambitiousness of the new generation but also highlighted their willingness to put significant effort in pursuit of their interests. In addition, by depicting Volodya's travel as productive, cheerful, and largely free of obstacles, Georgiy Daneliya subtly demonstrated the abundance of opportunities in the Soviet 1960s, encouraging young audiences to follow the character's path.

It is worth mentioning that the youth undertook transformative journeys in search of a better life across the union, as it was showcased in the work of Uchkun Nazarov. Similarly to Volodya, Sabir and Zulfiya left their rural homeland to fulfill their personal ambitions in a major city. By the 1960s, the capital of Uzbekistan was already an economically and infrastructurally well-developed city, which was systematically urbanized through state initiatives aimed at

“...повышения уровня благоустройства города и создания наиболее благоприятных условий для труда, быта и отдыха населения.”² At this point, Tashkent appeared as a city comparable to Moscow, which also attracted the attention of young people as a potential site of their new, better lives. Despite the fact that Sabir and Zulfiya were destined to follow different lifestyles, both of them still enjoyed the commodity and modernity of Tashkent (Figure 2).



Figure 2. Sabir and Zulfiya in a restaurant from *Boy and Girl*

In this instance, the journey to Tashkent was framed by the director as a fundamental phase that redefined characters, leading to significant changes in their personalities, behaviors, and values. Throughout the sequence of a life in a big city, the audiences could track the gradual evolution of Sabir and Zulfiya, who progressively became distant from their earlier rural identities. A similar process occurred with Yermakov, in the sense that by the end of the visit he did not necessarily change as a person but still gained new experiences and a romantic interest that supplemented his character. The following narratives proposed by Daneliya and Nazarov varied drastically from the cinematic stories of the Stalinist period, in which the characters' fulfillment derived from sacrifices for the benefit of the collective rather than personal transformation within a new

² “Postanovlenie Soveta Ministrov SSSR 21 fevralja 1967 g. Ob osnovnyh principah general'nogo plana razvitija g. Taškenta” In *Rešenija partii i pravitel'stva po hozjajstvennym voprosam*, (Politizdat: 1968), 336

setting. As a result, Soviet directors of the 1960s depicted a new wave of more expressive and self-directed youth that actively pursued individual ambitions over collective ideals.

Moreover, Soviet movies of the 1960s displayed a tendency to portray young characters maturing without present paternal figures, indicating the broader erosion of traditional family dynamics and increased autonomy of the new generation. The absence of fathers in the cinematic narratives revealed the socio-political climate of the period following the death of Joseph Stalin. The state agitprop systematically elevated the importance of the leader, employing slogans such as “...Сталин — наш вождь, учитель и отец.”³ In this context, Soviet films of the 1960s mirrored the loss of the all-union paternal authority by embracing young characters growing up without their fathers. It is worth noting that the absence of male parental figures did not seemingly bother the youth, which was especially evident in the work of Daneliya. The central character of the film, Kolya, exemplified the post-Stalinist generation that lacked paternal presence, as it was demonstrated by the dialogue between his grandmother and Volodya (Figure 3).



Figure 3. Kolya's grandmother talking to Yermakov from *Walking the Streets of Moscow*

³ “Naš vožd', učitel' i otec: Miting v N-skoj voinskoj časti” In *Odessa v Velikoj Otečestvennoj vojne Sovetskogo Sojuza*, (Bol'shevistskoe znamja: 1941), 47.

The memory of her sons taken by the Second World War left grandmother in a state of grief and sorrow, which was less apparent in Kolya's behavior, who proceeded to comfort her. The variability in emotions depicted in this scene fits into the broader trend evident in the Soviet visual culture of the postwar, as discussed by Claire McCallum. To be specific, visual media at the time exhibited a tendency to portray optimistic future-oriented representations of everyday life rather than scenes of fragmenting families facing postwar hardships⁴. In this case, Kolya's calm reaction appeared as a cinematic embodiment of this artistic trend, showcasing the youth psychologically detached from their lost fathers. The following indifference found its manifestation not only through emotions and behaviors of the characters but also via visual composition of the living space. It is important to note that Kolya's family resided in a well-equipped apartment (Figure 4) in the centre of Moscow.



Figure 4. Apartment of Kolya's family from *Walking the Streets of Moscow*

As McCallum further articulated their argument, comfortable domestic space was presented in Soviet postwar art as compensating for the absence of fathers, framing the paternalistic state as the main provider of new housing and other material benefits⁵. At this point, Daneliya's film showed that not only did the youth live in better conditions but also relied on the state as a

⁴ McCallum, Claire E. *The Return: Postwar Masculinity and the Domestic Space in Stalinist Visual Culture, 1945-53.*, no. 1 (The Russian Review: 2015), 135.

⁵ McCallum, *The Return: Postwar Masculinity and the Domestic Space in Stalinist Visual Culture*, 135.

substitute for paternal care, which allowed them to enjoy their lives in the postwar period despite the loss of their biological fathers.

The greater autonomy of young people was another important motif of the 1960s Soviet cinematography. For instance, *Wings* indicated a shift towards a more self-reliant generation capable of making choices without appealing to external authority through the character of Tanya. It was her decision to marry a significantly older man that became a central indicator of this individual agency and determination. Given Tanya's family situation, one could argue that her choice of the partner was directly connected to the absence of the father figure. The following claim finds its grounding in Lilya Kaganovsky's analysis of *Lenin's Guard*, which stated that the youth necessitated paternal advice on how they should live and that its lack complicated their maturation⁶. Therefore, the gap in paternal guidance could have been one of the contributing factors for Tanya to marry someone who had already held the position of power (instructor at an institute) and possessed greater experience in life compared to her. At this point, engagement with Igor was the way to fill Tanya's need for guidance as well as consolidation of her maturity and separation from her mother. The latter was additionally highlighted in the conversation between Nadezhda and Pavel when Petrukhina complained about her daughter's choice "Ну хоть бы посоветовалась, я же не чужая." Taken together, both films contributed to the portrayal of a more autonomous generation of young people shaped by redefined family dynamics (in which the paternal roles were assigned to the state or one's partner).

In addition, the youth depicted in 1960s Soviet cinematography embraced complete disengagement from traditional customs and ideological narratives of the past, exemplifying the break from principles that shaped earlier generations. To be exact, young characters featured in

⁶ Kaganovsky, Lilya. "Postmemory, Countermemory: Soviet Cinema of the 1960s." In *The Socialist Sixties: Crossing Borders in the Second World*, edited by Anne E. Gorsuch and Diane P. Koenker. (Indiana University Press: 2013), 240.

the films of the period did not simply disagree with values of the past but also explicitly opposed representatives of the older generation that embraced them. Sergey Bystryakov from *Wings* served as a direct manifestation of this phenomenon, embodying the rebellious spirit of nonconformity. Individualism of the character was effectively conveyed by the director through the scene in Nadezhda's office, where Bystryakov confessed his hatred to her (Figure 5).



Figure 5. Bystryakov in Petrukhina's office from *Wings*

In the conflict between the characters, Nadezhda represented the Stalinist generation guided by strict discipline, absolute compliance, and a sense of community. On the other hand, Bystryakov symbolized the youth that stood against the demands and restrictions of the past order. In his resistance, Bystryakov did not merely demonstrate his disagreement but indicated the formation of new communism among young people. Following the postwar period, the Soviet youth began to explore what socialism meant for them by questioning their opinions about socio-ideological, political, and moral issues⁷. 'In this regard, Larisa Shepitko articulated the image of a new wave of socialists who actively constructed their understanding of communism and were not afraid to resist the authority of the Stalinist generation through the character of Bystryakov. It is important to highlight that such youth were supported by Khrushchev: “Я думаю, что мы будем не правы,

⁷ Fürst, Juliane. “The arrival of spring? Changes and Continuities in Soviet Youth Culture and Policy between Stalin and Khrushchev” In *The Dilemmas of De-Stalinization*, ed. 1 (Routledge: 2006), 142..

если мы будем с молодежью разговаривать только вот так: бить по голове, это нельзя, это нельзя, это не то, это не то. Молодежь — это наше будущее, это те, которые будут строить коммунизм.”⁸ At this point, young dissenters (like Bystryakov) were encouraged and legitimized to reinterpret principles of previous generations, constituting the formation of a new socialist mentality under Khrushchev’s regime.

Furthermore, nonconformism exhibited by young characters of the 1960s cinematic narratives went beyond ideological matters, reaching traditional customs and practices. In this case, directors such as Nazarov indicated a fundamental break between the generations by presenting the refusal of the youth to adopt the lifestyle of their parents rooted in cultural norms. This was effectively shown in the sequence of Sabir’s dialogue with his mother right before his departure to Tashkent. Throughout the discussion she recalled her husband when he was Sabir’s age, emphasizing how he was already married and building a family. Complaining about the growing difficulty of performing household duties, Sabir’s mother advised him: “Женился бы поскорее, сынок. Зулфия хорошая девушка, красивая.” To which Sabir replied, “Она учиться едет,” ending the conversation. The following response reflected differing priorities of the two generations, as well as unwillingness of the youth to adhere to established principles. Although Sabir continued to dream about the wedding with Zulfiya, his actions proved that education appeared as a more prevalent and significant aspect of their lives. In this way, Nazarov contributed to Shepitko’s portrayal of dissident Soviet youth by demonstrating their noncompliance with traditional values.

In conclusion, Soviet cinematography of the 1960s sustained the image of the youth that valued personal aspirations over collective duty, grew without strong paternal figures, and

⁸ “*Stenogramma vstreči rukovoditelej KPSS i Sovetskogo pravitel'stva s dejateljami literatury i iskusstva*”, fond 52, opis’ 1, delo 330, (Ličnyj fond N.S. Hruševa, 1962), 562..

displayed a clear detachment from ideological and traditional values of the past. As a result, Soviet movies of the period contributed to cinematic legitimization of the younger generation that varied drastically from the earlier (especially Stalinist) cohorts. Young people embarked on transformative journeys in pursuit of their dreams and interests instead of serving the ideals of collectivism. Compared to the previous generations, the individual fulfillment of the 1960s youth derived from realizing their ambitions, rather than working for the collective good. In addition, due to the erosion of traditional family roles, young characters exhibited highly autonomous behavior, exhibiting detachment or relative indifference towards the absent father figures. Moreover, the new generation tended to develop their own ideological and moral frameworks that conflicted with the underlying values of their parents. For instance, young people refused to follow the path dictated by customary laws of their communities, while simultaneously constructing their own understandings of socialism. It is worth noting that the emergence of a new wave of youth was largely permitted and supported by the party, which was particularly evident in the sequence of Khrushchev speeches of the 1960s.

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Filmography

Boy and Girl [Парень и Девушка] (1968), dir. Uchkun Nazarov

Walking the Streets of Moscow [Я шагаю по Москве] (1964), dir. Georgiy Daneliya

Wings [Крылья] (1966), dir. Larisa Shepitko